

» OLYMPICS SPECIAL II INTERVIEW MIRABAI CHANU

Shining beacon: Having won a silver medal at the 2020 Tokyo Olympics, Mirabai Chanu will be one of India's biggest prospects in Paris. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

WEIGHING HER CHANCES ONE LIFT AT A TIME

Mirabai Chanu has made an inspiring comeback from her Asian Games injury last year and is now **training fiercely** for the Paris Olympics under the watchful eyes of coach Vijay Sharma.

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Before her training sessions at the National Institute of Sports in Patiala, Mirabai Chanu takes off her shoes and places them on a footwear rack next to the main entrance of the weightlifting hall, at the other end of which there is a **multi-faith shrine where she prays to the idol of Hanuman** — the Hindu patron deity of strength.

About a year ago, the idol was located at the other end of the hall where the rack now stands. It's something that Mirabai's coach, Vijay Sharma, often reminds her of. "We got the weightlifting hall renovated last year just before the Asian Games. That's when we moved the shrine to the other end of the hall, and where the shrine was, we replaced it with a shoe rack. I always tell Mira, one day

people will worship you, and the next day they'll treat you like a pair of shoes. **The only thing you can do is devote yourself to your work and leave the rest to God,**" he says.

Having won a silver medal at the 2020 Tokyo Olympics, the petite four-foot-eleven, 29-year-old from Manipur will be one of India's biggest prospects in Paris in about a month-and-a-half. A second Olympic